PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #52 · PTSD

“I can’t trust anyone. If I let my guard down, I’ll be hurt again.”

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Where it often comes from

Trust breaks when someone who should have been safe was not. After that, keeping everyone out can feel like the only wisdom left. The lie stretches a real betrayal into a rule about every person, and often about God too. Caution with unsafe people is not the same thing as “I can’t trust anyone.” A counselor can help you sort who is unsafe from who might be safe, without rushing you. A counselor can help you work with this at a pace that is safe. You do not have to do it alone, or all at once.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture does not say every person is trustworthy. It does say the Lord is on your side, and that you can trust Him with all your heart instead of leaning only on a frightened understanding. You can cast anxiety on Him because He cares. He is near the brokenhearted. Being hurt taught a hard lesson. It did not prove that no one, and not God, can ever be trusted again. Trust can be small, specific, and slow.

> *“The LORD is on my side; I will not be afraid. What can man do to me?”* (Psalm 118:6).

Also see

> “Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight” (Proverbs 3:5–6).

> “Cast all your anxiety on Him, because He cares for you” (1 Peter 5:7).

> “Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness” (Isaiah 41:10).

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

Common self-statements

- If I let anyone close, I will be hurt again.
- Kindness is a setup.
- I can only count on myself.
- God let it happen, so He is not safe either.
- Needing people is how I got hurt.
- I would rather be alone than risk it.

Common logical errors

- Overgeneralization: Turning one betrayal into “no one can be trusted.”
- Fortune telling: Deciding that closeness will certainly end in harm.
- Mind reading: Assuming a kind person has a hidden motive.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Either I trust everyone or I trust no one.

Challenging questions

- Who specifically broke my trust, and have I made that person stand for everyone?
- What would a small, limited trust look like?

- Am I protecting myself, or am I refusing every good person too?
- What does God say about His care, separate from what people did?
- Who has been safe, even in a small way?
- What has my counselor said about going slowly?

Truth summary

> I was hurt, and that does not mean I can never trust anyone. I can trust God, and I can test trust slowly with safe people.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

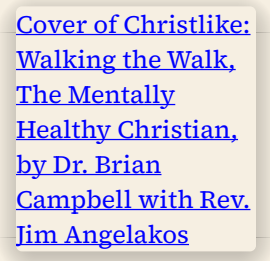
- Trust
- Fear
- Love, By God
- Loneliness
- Friendship

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Love
- Anxiety/Worry/Fear
- Thinking, Healthy

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from "The Mentally Healthy Christian" (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

The God Who Stays — Matthew West
God stays when people have failed you. That does not mean every person will.

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
You are not left without a companion, even when trust feels impossible.

He Knows — Jeremy Camp
Jesus knows what it is to be hurt, and He does not turn that into "trust no one."

What a Friend We Have in Jesus — Keith and Kristyn Getty
You can bring a guarded heart to God before you hand it to a person.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

My Plan for Replacing "I can't trust anyone. If I let my guard down, I'll be hurt again."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I can't trust anyone. If I let my guard down, I'll be hurt again." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who specifically broke my trust, and have I made that person stand for everyone?
- ☐ What would a small, limited trust look like?
- ☐ Am I protecting myself, or am I refusing every good person too?
- ☐ What does God say about His care, separate from what people did?
- ☐ Who has been safe, even in a small way?
- ☐ What has my counselor said about going slowly?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I was hurt, and that does not mean I can never trust anyone. I can trust God, and I can test trust slowly with safe people.
- ☐ Not every person is the person who hurt me.
- ☐ I can trust God even while I am careful with people.
- ☐ Trust can be one small step, not an open door to everyone.
- ☐ Caution is wise. Total isolation is the lie.
- ☐ God is near the brokenhearted.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 118:6
  "The LORD is on my side; I will not be afraid. What can man do to me?"
- ☐ Proverbs 3:5–6
  "Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight."
- ☐ 1 Peter 5:7
  "Cast all your anxiety on Him, because He cares for you."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When trust felt impossible: Each day, write down one moment when closeness felt like a setup. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 118:6 becomes: "Sarah can write: "The Lord is on my side. I do not have to trust everyone to trust Him.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Trust" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- [ ] Separate one person from everyone. Write the name of who hurt you. Then write "This is not every person."
- [ ] One limited step. With your counselor, choose one safe person and one small trust, such as a short conversation. Stop there.
- [ ] Notice kindness without explaining it away. When someone is decent to you, write what they did before you decide it was fake.
- [ ] Pray Psalm 118:6 when the rule "trust no one" shows up.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I can't trust anyone. If I let my guard down, I'll be hurt again.": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A moment of small, real trust
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I can't trust anyone. If I let my guard down, I'll be hurt again~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I learned not to trust, and the lesson was costly. Be a safe place for me. Help me not to call every person dangerous, and help me go slowly with the people who are. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.